

Gender Values, Cultural Expectations, and Social Change in Nso people Society. *Written and presented by Fengai Fortibui, Florence Fonka*

Introduction: Across many Cameroonian societies, cultural traditions and long-established social structures have historically shaped perceptions regarding the roles and value of male and female children within families and communities. In Nso society in the Northwest Region of Cameroon, these traditions have influenced inheritance systems, educational opportunities, leadership expectations, and family responsibilities. Although significant social changes have emerged through modernization, education, migration, religion, and advocacy for gender equality, traditional attitudes toward the boy child and the girl child continue to influence certain aspects of social life.

Historically, the boy child has often been regarded as the principal carrier of lineage, inheritance, and family continuity, while girls have largely been associated with domestic responsibilities and marriage into other families. However, contemporary realities increasingly reveal that women and girls contribute substantially to economic development, education, caregiving, leadership, and community advancement. At the same time, many men continue to fulfill important responsibilities within the family and society. These changing realities demonstrate that competence, responsibility, and social contribution are not determined by gender, but rather by opportunity, upbringing, and individual character.

Patrilineal Inheritance and Family Continuity: Although Nso society traces its historical origins to Princess Ngonso, the social structure remains predominantly patrilineal. Family identity, lineage, and inheritance are traditionally transmitted through male descendants. Sons are commonly regarded as custodians of the family name, ancestral heritage, and cultural continuity. Property, land, and traditional titles are typically inherited by male children, while daughters are often excluded from inheritance because they are expected to marry into other families.

This patrilineal structure has historically elevated the social value of boys within families and communities. The expectation that sons would preserve the lineage and maintain

family influence contributed significantly to the preferential treatment of male children in many traditional settings.

Economic Expectations and Family Investment: Traditional perceptions within Nso society have frequently associated boys with future economic security. Sons are often viewed as future providers who will support their parents in old age, preserve family property, and contribute to the stability of the extended family structure. Consequently, families have historically invested more heavily in the education, training, and economic preparation of male children.

Girls, by contrast, have often been perceived as temporary members of their natal households because marriage would eventually transfer their primary responsibilities to another family. This perception contributed to unequal access to resources and opportunities between boys and girls, particularly in periods of economic hardship or limited educational access.

Educational Opportunities and Gender Roles: Historically, educational opportunities in many Nso families favored boys when resources were limited. This preference was based on the belief that investing in sons would yield greater long-term returns for the family. As a result, girls were more likely to remain at home to assist with domestic responsibilities, agricultural labor, childcare, and household management.

Traditional gender expectations also shaped socialization patterns. Boys were generally prepared for leadership, decision-making, and public responsibilities, while girls were socialized into caregiving and domestic roles. These divisions reflected broader cultural understandings of masculinity and femininity within society.

Ritual, Spiritual, and Cultural Responsibilities: Many traditional rituals, ancestral rites, and cultural responsibilities within Nso society have historically been reserved for men. Sons are often expected to inherit their fathers' traditional titles and ceremonial functions after reaching maturity. Certain spiritual responsibilities and ancestral obligations are also traditionally restricted to male descendants.

These practices reinforced the perception that men occupied positions of greater cultural and spiritual authority within society. In some cases, religious institutions further reflected similar gendered limitations in leadership and ceremonial participation.

Protection and Social Security: Traditionally, men were regarded as protectors of both the household and the wider community. Historical experiences involving territorial defense, inter-community conflict, and social protection strengthened the association between masculinity and communal security. Men were expected to defend the society, preserve its territorial integrity, and provide physical protection for their families.

As a result, boys were often valued for their anticipated future role as defenders and protectors of both family and society.

Contemporary Contributions of Girls and Women: Economic Participation and Financial Responsibility: Contemporary realities within Nso society increasingly demonstrate the major economic contributions of women. Many women have become successful entrepreneurs, professionals, traders, educators, healthcare workers, and public servants. Through their labor and professional achievements, women frequently provide substantial support to both immediate and extended family members.

In many households, daughters contribute significantly to family welfare, educational expenses, healthcare support, and broader economic stability. These contributions challenge earlier assumptions that only male children can secure the long-term financial well-being of families.

Caregiving and Support for Aging Parents: Contrary to traditional expectations that sons would primarily assume responsibility for aging parents, many daughters actively provide emotional, physical, and financial care for their families throughout adulthood. Married and unmarried women alike often maintain strong connections with their natal families and continue to support parents and relatives long after marriage.

These realities increasingly demonstrate that many responsibilities, and natal family care are not exclusively tied to male children.

Educational Achievement and Professional Advancement: Where girls are granted equal educational opportunities, many excel academically and professionally. Nso women have achieved distinction in medicine, engineering, business, education, law, politics, and other professional sectors. Their achievements illustrate the broader social and economic benefits of investing equally in the education of girls and boys.

Educational advancement among women has also contributed to changing perceptions regarding gender roles, leadership, and intellectual capability within society.

Leadership and Community Development: Women in Nso society continue to play critical roles in community development, religious participation, market organization, healthcare initiatives, and social welfare activities. Through women's associations, cooperative groups, local markets, and grassroots development initiatives, women contribute significantly to community stability and collective progress.

The active participation and leadership of women in religious institutions, economic organizations, and community networks further demonstrates their central role in sustaining social cohesion and cultural continuity within Nso and beyond.

Resilience and Social Transformation: Despite historical limitations and structural barriers, many Nso women have demonstrated resilience in overcoming challenges related to gender expectations, educational access, and economic opportunity. Their success increasingly contributes to changing cultural narratives regarding the capabilities and social value of women and girls.

As more women attain educational and professional success, families and communities are gradually recognizing that daughters are equally capable of preserving family dignity, supporting relatives, and contributing to societal cohesion and advancement.

The Continuing Contributions of Men in Contemporary Society : Family Responsibility and Economic Provision: While contemporary discussions increasingly highlight the contributions of women, many Nso men continue to fulfill important responsibilities within families and communities. Men and women, sons and daughters of Nso each in their own right, frequently provide financial support, participate in decision-making, assist extended relatives, as well as contribute to household stability. Many sons and daughters remain committed to caring for aging parents and maintaining family responsibilities throughout adulthood.

Leadership and Mentorship: Men continue to play influential roles in leadership, mentorship, and social guidance within families and communities. Through participation in traditional institutions, community organizations, and development initiatives, many men contribute to social order, conflict resolution, and intergenerational mentorship. Positive male role models also contribute significantly to shaping values of discipline, responsibility, and integrity among younger generations.

Community Development and Social Progress: Nso men have historically participated in community development projects, including road construction, water systems, healthcare initiatives, educational development, and local governance. Their contributions remain important in fostering social resilience and collective advancement.

At the same time, contemporary social changes increasingly encourage more balanced family relationships in which men participate actively in parenting, emotional support, and domestic responsibilities alongside women.

Changing Perspectives and the Pursuit of Gender Balance: Modernization, urbanization, formal education, migration, and global discussions surrounding gender equality continue to influence changing attitudes within Nso society, particularly among the Western Educated Nso sons and daughters. Increasingly, families recognize that social contribution, leadership, and responsibility are not determined solely by gender. Instead, values such as education, discipline, opportunity, and character play a greater role in shaping individual success and societal contribution.

The gradual transformation of gender expectations does not necessarily require the rejection of cultural identity or traditional values. Rather, it invites a reconsideration of how cultural practices can evolve in ways that preserve social cohesion while promoting fairness, inclusion, and equal opportunity for all members of society.

Conclusion: The historical preference for the boy child within Nso society emerged from deeply rooted cultural, economic, and social structures related to inheritance, lineage, protection, and family continuity. These traditions shaped unequal value allocations, expectations and opportunities for boys and girls over many generations.

However, contemporary experiences increasingly demonstrate that intelligence, leadership, resilience, caregiving, and economic contribution are not determined by gender. Women and men alike contribute significantly to family welfare, cultural preservation, and community development within Nso society.

A balanced and progressive perspective therefore requires equal recognition of the abilities and potential of both boys and girls. By promoting equitable opportunities while respecting cultural identity, Nso society can continue to strengthen its social foundations and encourage the full participation of all its members in the advancement of Nso.